interests of dominant urban society with those of the urban poor has, in practice, ended up subverting the latter. The bank-Marcos strategy has been to evict squatters from their residential sites in the central areas of Manila in order to open up the latter to commercial and industrial use by foreign multinationals. The squatters are then transferred either to shantytowns in outlying areas that are almost inaccessible to their jobs in the central city, or to government-constructed housing projects that rent at prices far above the squatters' reach.

(4) *Financial discipline.* The bank's policies in this field, which have been closely worked out with its sister institution, the IMF, have been followed almost point by point by the Marcos regime. Presenting them as measures to "sanitize" the debt management of the country, the government has obediently cheapened the peso through periodic devaluations; imposed tight credit and monetary policies which have had devastating effects on credit-dependent Filipino businessmen; opened up the local banking industry to virtual takeover by U.S. financial giants like Chemical Bank, Citibank and the Bank of America, and lifted virtually all controls on the repatriation of profits and investments in foreign exchange, a policy which has resulted in a massive drain of dollars and forced the country into even deeper debt to private banks and international financial institutions.

(5) *Population control.* Robert McNamara and R.T. Ravenholt, head of AID's population division, have the reputation of being the most vocal proponents of population control as a means to solve the problems of the Third World. The World Bank and USAID have now teamed up to fund and supervise in the Philippines what is perhaps the biggest of all population-control programs. A gigantic World Bank loan of $25 million has recently supplemented the $37.5 million which USAID has so far sunk into the project. The program has now embarked on "voluntary sterilization," with experimental teams trained in laparoscopy and vasectomy fanning out in the country to "popularize" the procedures. If the experience of India, the bank's top contractor of loans, is any indication, voluntary sterilization may be just the prelude to coerced sterilization.

Five of the top eight recipients of World Bank loans are right-wing dictatorships. It is no accident; the bank's basic technocratic view of development cannot tolerate the give and take of democratic conflict and is inherently biased toward straightforward bureaucratic initiatives.

Tied to Marcos's technocrats by a common ideology, the bank, not surprisingly, has become an apologist for a regime that, by its own admission, has jailed some 50,000 persons since the imposition of martial law:

> While the country is formally under martial law, the basic strategy of government is to resort as little as possible to outright coercion and to broaden popular support through the development of effective economic and social programs.

Technocratic ideology, in other words, has become an ally, cover and instrument of the class interests of the Philippines' ruling elite and the imperial interests of the United States in the country.

In sum, the Philippines today is not only heavily in debt to the World Bank but its economic policies are formulated and supervised by the bank itself. The bank is not an autonomous institution, and the interests served by its policies in the Philippines are essentially those of the United States. These policies have not contributed to the development of the Philippines. Indeed, their results have been, to paraphrase Andre Gunder Frank, to develop and deepen the underdevelopment of the Philippines. □

INDIANS AND RANCHERS

BAD DAYS ON THE RESERVATION

KIM C. ROGAL

One guy came out here and said to me, all right, let's say all this land is yours. So if you get all this land back and push all these white people off what are you going to do? And I said I'm going to buy me a white horse. Every morning I'm going to saddle that horse and I'm going to ride up on top of that hill and I'm going to sit on top of that hill and watch my land. Watch the grass wave in the wind, and the birds fly around. That's what it means, because land is sacred to me . . . all these years we never leased this out, and we never farmed it ourselves, but it provided for us, with wild fruits and chokecherries, and my aunt used to plant a garden here and it's ours.

Severt Youngbear, aged 41 at his house near Porcupine, on Pine Ridge Reservation.

About thirty minutes across the rutted, dusty roads from Severt Youngbear's house in Porcupine is the white man's town of Batesland, which may or may not be on the edge of the Pine Ridge Indian Reservation, depending on whose map you accept. Bureau of Indian Affairs (BIA) land maps show Batesland to be squarely inside the reservation, but a Rand McNally road map available at all local gas stations chops off a large chunk from the southeast section of Pine Ridge. Those 800,000 acres are shown on the gas station map as Bennett County; it contains the richest farm land in the whole 2-million-acre area which the BIA still calls a reservation for the Oglala Sioux.

The gas station map is more up to date, since it acknowledges a reality: that the land in Bennett County

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is almost wholly owned or leased by white farmers, and that the whites claim allegiance to the state of South Dakota, not to the Bureau of Indian Affairs or to the Indian-elected tribal government.

Many readers may be surprised to learn that whites own any land at all on the Indian reservation. In fact, white control goes far beyond Batesland and the Bennett County border. Lawrence Heald, director of land operations for the Pine Ridge Reservation, estimates that whites own or lease a full 90 per cent of the farm land on Pine Ridge, and 75 per cent of the ranch land. What appears on all the maps to be the Pine Ridge Reservation is a kind of illusion; a true map would show a mosaic of Indian-owned land segments, intermixed with the white-owned land. White spots, since they are a source of tax revenue for the state of South Dakota, might then actually be interpreted as non-federal, even non-reservation land.

For mapping purposes, however, and more importantly for law-enforcement purposes, the entire 2 million acres are still considered the province of the Oglala Sioux, one of a coalition of once powerful Sioux tribes which hardly more than a century ago had title through treaty with the U.S. Government to most of the land in what's now about four states west of the Missouri River.

Marion Schultz is a white rancher who lives in the town of Batesland. His father settled on Indian land in the 1930s, when the BIA was encouraging Indians to sell their reservation acreage to non-Indians. Land now worth between $200 and $300 an acre was sold—right through the 1950s—for prices often ranging between $8 and $13 an acre, always with the consent of the bureau. Such sales continued into the early 1960s, when elected tribal governments first began to assert themselves and attempts were made to impose a moratorium on further sales to non-Indians.

Schultz's father acquired over the years 4,000 acres of deeded land and 16 acres of leased land for his cattle operations. The Schultzes are now among the small number of white ranchers, hardly more than 100, who together own or lease 75 per cent of the reservation ranch land.

The ever increasing white control of reservation land is a source of satisfaction to Marion Schultz and to his father, since the controlling interest advances the cause of a new group which these two men helped organize. It is called Civil Liberties for South Dakota Citizens (CLSDC), and is a combined law-and-order "protection" organization and a political group which advocates, for the short term, state instead of federal jurisdiction over law enforcement on the reservation, and, for the long term, the termination of reservations, and the abandonment of any semblance of treaty agreements between the U.S. Government and the Indian peoples.

Schultz freely admits he's trying to "force an issue." A soft-spoken, college-educated man in his 30s, he's generally acknowledged to be a spokesman for the ranchers and farmers of the group. What exactly does Schultz intend to do? A leaflet about Civil Liberties for South Dakota Citizens explains two of the group's proposed goals:

> ¶To inculcate and stimulate the love of our country and the flag.
>
> ¶To defend the honor, integrity and supremacy of our National Government and the Constitutions of the United States and the state of South Dakota, subordinating all others but recognizing, in conformity with those constitutions, the rights of the individual citizen.

The leaflet nowhere states that the group's ultimate aim is to abolish reservations, but Schultz acknowledges that intention. Nor does the printed literature, which is concerned mainly with legal and political questions, mention that members of the group have bought guns and communications equipment for their "protection."

CLSDC, which began at Pine Ridge, now claims about 3,000 members in South Dakota and a fast-expanding membership in other reservation states. It has also affiliated with the National Rifle Association because, according to Schultz, many sportsmen in states like Washington would like to come into Indian reservations to hunt. A still embryonic national group, tentatively called the Interstate Congress on Equal Rights and Responsibilities is already evolving from the South Dakota organization, and affiliated groups have sprung up in ten states. An immediate goal, according to Schultz, is to "have Congress take a look at the situation.

"The power to make treaties lies with Congress, and they can disavow any treaty they so desire. . . . So the power to make them is the power to break them . . . or change them. Sure, there have been many cases where they [Indians] did come up on the short end of the stick, but how long must one pay for one's mistakes?"

Schultz believes that an important hindrance to legislation favoring the ranchers' group is "sympathy [for Indians] from primarily the Eastern population that doesn't really understand the problem."

> In one sense what they've [Indians] got going is a private club, just like the Elks Club, and it'd be like the Elks Club in your town all of a sudden passing laws and regulations for the entire town to live under, and the rest of the town can't participate in the lawmaking —it's a private club. . . . We're all citizens of the state and the nation, and we should all live under the same set of laws, and live under the same judicial system. We've got no complaint with their tribal government or anything else, it's just that they should get out of law enforcement, because traditionally it hasn't worked for them, and the FBI thing doesn't work.

Law enforcement has been the focal point for organizing the CLSDC. In fact, it began, according to Schultz, in direct response to the outbreak of Indian militancy in 1973 at Pine Ridge, during the seventy-one-day occupation of a small cluster of buildings in the countryside not far from Batesland, at an historic place called Wounded Knee. The whites, fearing property damage and harassment from the Indians involved in the protest, met with state law-enforcement officials and requested their presence on the reservation. As Schultz remembers it, "The federal fellows were there, and the state said, 'good luck, we have nothing to do with you.' And the federal government said 'We don't have any-



Marion Schultz

thing to do with you'—and we were paying for a law-enforcement officer with tax money and he never even came into the county. . . . So we formed the Tri-County Protection Association (also called the Ranchers' Protection Association). . . . It was strictly defensive—it's been accused of being a vigilante group, but vigilante takes on the connotation of being an offensive group, which we are not."

Schultz is right that the state police have no jurisdiction on the reservation, as the mapped boundaries define it, but his contention that the federal police denied all responsibility for the white ranchers is questionable. Ken Sayers, Agency Special Officer for the BIA police (the equivalent in Pine Ridge of a police chief) denies that federal authorities ever said "we have nothing to do with you." The BIA police and the FBI, he says, share a full range of powers to investigate crimes and make arrests on the reservation.

But Schultz and his group are aware that they've hit a nerve when they attack the law-enforcement question. Ever since whites first bought Indian land and settled on the reservations, their status under the law has been confusing. One of the major problems has been what to do with the whites themselves if they're to be arrested. The tribe has its own court for misdemeanors, but the whites have always objected to being tried in an Indian court with Indian judges or juries. As a compromise, any white arrested on the reservation is to be turned over within twenty-four hours to state officials and prosecuted under the white man's judicial system. That compromise is one source of confusion as to the legal status of whites on the reservation.

It's possible that whites at times have had difficulties dealing with the BIA police. It's also possible that the entire matter is a red herring, since the confusion centers around prosecution in the courts, and not around the initial arrests. In fact, some Indians on the reservation complain that the BIA and the FBI protect white property more zealously than they do Indian lives. Nonetheless, whites and Indians alike have complained, for a variety of reasons, about the enforcement of the law on the reservation.

Many members of the Indian community have accused the "protection" association of having been, from the first, an alarmist group which has exaggerated the threat to white ranchers and farmers. Al Trimble, the newly elected Tribal President, says of the white organization, "It's vigilantes is what the hell they are. All this C.B. [Citizens' Band radio] stuff. They've upgraded the old cowboys and Indians game, that's all they've done. You know when you really look at it you wonder how adult juveniles like that can be so successful accumulating money and running a ranching operation. It makes me wonder why Indians aren't running ranching operations. They just don't have the tradition of accumulating. They just haven't been that way. They've essentially been communal people, and when anyone wants to point out to you a large Indian rancher on a reservation, invariably they're one-eighth [by blood], and they've passed; they can go out and talk to any banker."

Schultz admits that most of the violence on the reservation has been "between and among Indians," but insists that the threat to the whites remains imminent, particularly since Wounded Knee. The police say that whites have suffered considerable property damage and some cattle theft in the past few years, but that actual violence directed at white residents has been minimal. In fact, the lack of violence directed at whites is in stark contrast to the staggering crime rate on the reservation. In 1975, there were more than 300 felonies, including beatings, stabbings, rapes and assaults, and at least seventeen homicides—a tremendous number of violent crimes considering the fact that only 15,000 people live on the reservation. Two of those seventeen dead were white men, but they were also FBI agents, who walked into a rural encampment of Indians known to be armed and antagonistic to the FBI.

For whites Pine Ridge is no doubt safer than most inner cities, but then whites have been fleeing those embattled areas. With their considerable land, crop and livestock investments, Pine Ridge whites aren't so willing to pack up and move. The question, then, is whether the existence of armed groups like the Ranchers' Association increases the potential for a showdown between whites and Indians.

Bud May, a CLSDC member, speculates on the possibility of such a showdown. "If there ever comes a shoot-

out, it'll be a war. I think the blood'll run deep . . . 'cause there's a lot of us that won't run. . . . If they remove me it's going to be in a box."

Those are his fighting words, but most of the time May is an amiable, if opinionated, rancher in his early 40s, who lives in a modest house miles from any main road, in the heart of an 8,162-acre spread owned by his wife, Ada May, one-eighth Oglala Sioux, and an enrolled member of the tribe. Her tribal membership provides Ada May with what's called "Indian preference," a BIA-sponsored policy under which she has the right to meet any non-Indian's bid if she's interested in leasing a particular segment of reservation land.

In May's view, problems on the reservation began when the American Indian Movement (AIM) first appeared at Pine Ridge in 1972, "I've lived here all my life," he says, "and we've always got along with Indians. My wife's a member of the tribe, and my children are all members. They try to brand me as a radical prejudiced racist, but I don't think so. I have a lot of friends who're full-bloods, mixed-bloods, as good a people as there are. I don't think you should generalize in nationalities. There's scum in every race, and they had them all at Wounded Knee. They had the whites, and Negroes, and Chicanos. . . . There wasn't very many Indian people there when they went in to see who was there, when they finally negotiated their settlement."

According to Bud, "They had a hit list made up at Wounded Knee and she [Ada] was number-one Indian rancher. . . . They had six Mexican hit men here at one time I was told by the head of the BIA police—we had a meeting with him—he came out here and told us what to do in case of trouble. Del Eastman [head of the BIA police before Sayers]—they had to get rid of him, he was too good."

Asked about the advice from the BIA police, May said, "They'll tell you one thing off the record, and another thing at public meetings. . . . You ask any of these marshals and FBI men that's around during Wounded Knee, 'Well, what if somebody does come in and try to come into your house or steal something, or make trouble? —and they say, well, 'Shoot 'em.' They'll say that off the record. And they also said if you shot 'em be sure and kill them, cause then they won't testify against you."

What have the Mays done for self-defense? "We can take care of ourselves. There's been a lot of money spent for guns, communications, so forth, but only as a last resort. . . . What I'm always afraid of is that . . . one of these characters'll get drunk and shoot somebody and then there'll be retaliation. And if they ever have a shoot-out it won't be white man and Indian, it'll be whites and a certain segment of the Indians against the AIM, the longhairs. The AIM against the whites and quite a segment of the other Indians, who'll go together against the violent ones."

The "longhairs" May refers to are generally young AIM supporters, who wear braids or long hair and identify fiercely with Indian history and tradition. AIM has found considerable support on the reservation, mainly from full-blooded Indians of all ages, who tend to be poorer than the mixed-bloods and who have traditionally had less political influence with the BIA and the tribal government.

Mixed-bloods, like Ada May, have come to be identified by some segments of the reservation population with whites and white life style. Polarization increased between mixed-bloods and full-bloods during and after the Wounded Knee occupation, when Tribal President Richard Wilson, who preceded Al Trimble, bitterly opposed AIM and the demonstrators. Wilson was accused by AIM supporters of favoring the mixed-bloods in political matters—especially those relating to federal housing projects, a hot subject in a place where many people live in shacks. Wilson supporters were branded "goons" by AIM members. At least some of Wilson's followers accepted the title, and even created an acronym to fit the initials: Guardians of the Oglala Nation. They took up arms against AIM, and gun battles on the reservation between the two Indian factions still continue, despite the fact that Trimble, backed by AIM, defeated Wilson in a contest for Tribal President.

Thus Bud May's statement: "It'll be whites and a certain segment of the Indians against the AIM—the longhairs" is partially an accurate picture of the divisiveness at Pine Ridge. Where does May think AIM draws its support? "You want me to tell you the truth? It's communism. Did you know that Banks [Dennis Banks, an AIM leader] was arrested in Mexico and he called Kissinger person to person and got out of jail down there within hours?"

Bud contends that AIM is armed with Communist weapons. He also believes, on the word of an Indian friend who entered the occupied buildings at Wounded Knee, that "they had box after box of penicillin for the V.D. epidemic in there with Chinese writing on it." About the guns purchased by the Civil Liberties group, Bud says: "Everything we buy is legal. Semi-automatic. You cannot own a full automatic weapon legally. We stay within the law. Stupid law-abiding citizens."

Pine Ridge is a small community and frequently the most unlikely people turn out to be blood relations. AIM-backed Tribal President Trimble, for example, himself just under one-half Oglala Sioux, is a distant cousin of Ada May. Trimble, however, married a full-blooded Indian, and their children can claim a far greater degree of Indian blood than can Bud and Ada's. Trimble places considerable importance on the matter of blood degree. "The big danger to the tribe right now is the large number of small-degree Indians on the rolls who have managed to acquire a lot of land. The fact that they are predominantly white has given them an advantage that the Indian people don't tend to protect in their own way of living here on the reservation."

Trimble, aged 47, born and brought up at Pine Ridge, is a career BIA man and a former BIA superintendent on the reservation. As he tells it, his tenure at Pine Ridge lasted only about a year before he and former Tribal President Wilson "got crossways," and after a number of well-publicized political battles, Trimble was transferred to New Mexico. He retired from the BIA a few months later, and returned from what he considers his "exile"

to "see what I could do with the reservation from the tribal side as opposed to from the bureau side."

About Ada May, Trimble says, "She holds Indian preference, and she's been able to exercise it really to her advantage. When I was superintendent, there was a land sale pending. An Indian woman was selling her half-section of land [to Ada May], and I declined to approve it because I had seen where she [Ada May] had sold about 3,000 acres out of trust for the purpose of buying more land, and that's sort of dishonest. It isn't dishonest to an aggressive non-Indian person who's simply following his instincts to accumulate, but according to the Indian tradition of people on the reservation here it's surely not right, because it's endangering the future of the whole reservation here, for future generations. She bought a lot of land, and then to buy more Indian land because she had this technical right she fee-patented it in order to have free use of the mortgage income to buy more Indian lands. So if you had an Indian person that really wanted to, they could buy the reservation out that way . . . buy land, put a fee-patent on it, hawk the land, buy more. She [Ada May] has accumulated over 6,000 acres already, so the threat is really there, isn't it? The area director of the bureau countermanded me and permitted her to buy it anyway."

Ada May's case illustrates the fact that the tribal moratorium on taking land out of trust is only a kind of moral restraint, not legally binding. Under present regulations, if a tribal member insists on selling out reservation land, very little can be done about it. However, Trimble has set up an "enrollment committee" which seeks to revise and strengthen the tribal constitution on matters pertaining to membership in the tribe and Indian preference. One change would ban the sale of land to Indians who have a record of selling land out of trust to non-Indian users. Another possible change would deny enrollment to anyone of less than one-fourth Oglala Sioux descent. The regulation, says Trimble, wouldn't affect current members of the tribe, no matter what their blood degree, but would hold for anyone born after the policy was enacted.

He estimates that 40 per cent of the Indians on the reservation could claim to be full-blooded Oglala Sioux. This group contains the highest number of welfare clients, and faces the worst problems with alcoholism and unemployment. Estimates vary on the reservation's unemployment rate, but the Office of Financial Management for the Bureau of Indian Affairs puts it at approximately 35 per cent, particularly during the off seasons on the local farms and ranches. Alcoholism is one of the worst problems, particularly for the full-bloods. Trimble says, "A great many of the full-blood people don't drink, they don't believe in the use of alcohol, but the ones that do drink really find it a problem. There's nothing genealogical or chemical or anything like that about an Indian drinking—it's simply the fact that most of the people not able to cope with alcoholism or drinking problems are the lowest welfare clients that really don't have enough money to drink and eat both."

An almost unbearable litany of ills affect the Oglalas, including the incredible rates of unemployment, alcoholism and crime, but the problem with the most far-reaching implications, in Trimble's mind, is the loss of reservation land. His administration appears to be dedicated to reversing the trend toward the dissolution of the reservation advocated by Schultz and the Civil Liberties group.

> A lot of the resistance you see from groups like the Civil Liberties comes from the fact that tribal government has been developing a lot more aggressively with regard to land acquisition and land usage. They [whites] lived for years on this reservation practically a colonialistic existence—they had one set of rules which naturally were very favorable to them, and the rest of the people had another set of rules. So if these people really do believe in real civil liberties, why don't they choose to obey the laws of the people that own the reservation? . . . No one told them they had to live on Pine Ridge Reservation. Some of them came out here because they thought it was a good thing.
>
> The thing we're really advocating now is to get the momentum reversed. In other words pick up a quarter here and a quarter there [quarter-section or 160 acres], and pretty soon the person that has been counting on just the reverse situation happening . . . well, they'd get the picture that that's not going to happen.

When Severt Youngbear graduated from high school his grandmother wanted to give him a present. She sold a quarter-section of the family land for $9,000 to buy him a house, and to give him some spending money. He left the reservation and joined the army, then came back to live with his family on a remaining 160 acres of inherited land. Now 41, he's lived on that land ever since, supporting himself and his family by working as a ranch hand on white men's ranches on the reservation.

"As a kid," says Youngbear, "I rode horseback between here and Kyle and Wounded Knee and Oglala, and it was all open range—no fences. We'd graze our cattle and run our horses more or less in common range."

A "grazing resolution" adopted by the BIA in the early 1950s ended the communality of the reservation. According to Youngbear, the reservation was divided into grazing "units," the idea being to utilize the land better for agriculture, and as many units as possible were to be leased to the highest bidders for grazing.

Since there was to be no more haphazard, common grazing, a rancher needed substantial financing to operate an economically viable "unit." The BIA required that no more than five or six head of cattle be permitted to graze per quarter-section. So to run a sizable herd a rancher needed at least 2,000 acres.

Large "range units" were quickly fenced off, as white ranchers moved in to lease as much acreage as possible. Though leasing to the white operators brought income to the tribe, smaller Indian operators, like Youngbear's father, were driven out of business, because they were unable to borrow enough money to expand their operations to fit the new, more competitive requirements for grazing on the reservation. In 1955, the year the grazing resolution was first enforced, the elder Youngbear's small ranch went bankrupt.

Youngbear has been a strong AIM supporter. He was involved in both the Yellow Thunder and the Wounded Knee protests, and later testified at the trials of AIM leaders who were prosecuted for their actions at Wounded Knee. He's not bitter, he says, toward "the individual white

rancher . . . but I'm bitter at the BIA, because they're the ones that have done this to us. They're supposed to hold a trusteeship over Indian people . . . they're our protectors of land, of human rights, civil rights, but they pushed us to one side and they let this white rancher in. He can borrow money so he can outbid us and put us out of business, but why should I be bitter at him for what the BIA's done?"

After his father went out of business in 1955, the family kept the quarter-section, and "for a long time while grandmother was alive she let Frank Grooms, that's a white rancher here—she let him cut the hay for nothing. And during the winter time he'd come over and open a road for us. And at one time this rancher here and my uncle were almost like brothers, and Frank Grooms used to break horses for my grandmother. . . ."

The white ranchers and the Indians no longer enjoy such warm relations at Pine Ridge. While Severt Youngbear was using his house as a place to stockpile tons of food for the AIM protesters at Wounded Knee, a white rancher named William Leavitt, a member of the Ranchers' Protection Association, was plotting with his group to drop explosives on the demonstrators. The scheme was revealed during the trial of AIM leaders Russell Means and Dennis Banks.

Violence has increased now at Pine Ridge since the time when Leavitt and the ranchers' group hatched the plot to bomb the demonstrators. In 1970, according to BIA records, Pine Ridge had one murder, then two murders in 1971, one murder in 1972, four murders in 1973 (the year of the Wounded Knee occupation), ten murders in 1974 and seventeen murders in 1975. Police say that each murder is statistically equivalent to eight murders in a city with a population of 100,000.

The rancher's group angers many of the Indians in the tribe. It seems to epitomize some of the deepest Indian fears about white intentions. Severt Youngbear says of the group that its purpose is to "kill Indians. So if we're going to get this land back, and all these white people are buying land and starting this civil liberties organization, they have no business doing that. Because from the beginning this land was ours and it's still ours. And whatever land that they bought it's not our fault, it's the BIA's fault. So if they want their money back they have to get it from the government, they're the ones that did it to us, because they're the ones that stole our land from us. I think we should sue to get all the land back from the ranchers, because they came here and they squatted on the land, and in good faith we let them stay. But the land is still ours."

A young AIM member, Charles Long Soldier, sitting on the steps of the tribal offices, proposed another method of dealing with white ranchers and farmers on the Indian reservation. "Let's chase them off the land," he said.

Long Soldier's idea is widely subscribed to by young, radical AIM supporters on Pine Ridge. □

DEFOLIANT 2,4,5-T

ECOLOGICAL RUSSIAN ROULETTE

R. DOUGLAS CLARK

Trichlorophenoxyacetic acid. The tongue works its way through the words like a rat through a maze. Usually called 2,4,5-T, this acid is the active ingredient in hundreds of different herbicides. Although it had been sold widely in the United States since the late 1940s, 2,4,5-T first attracted public attention in the late 1960s for its use in Vietnam—where it was the defoliant spray called Agent Orange.* Public protest forced the military to discontinue its use of Agent Orange in 1969. Today there is growing pressure to ban 2,4,5-T in this country as well. 2,4,5-T belongs to a group of compounds called the "phenoxy herbicides," which kill broad-leaf plants by altering their growth processes. Proponents claim that they are a thorough and economical means of eliminating undesirable vegetation. Environmentalists argue that this interference destroys the necessary ecological balance. Moreover, they fear that the phenoxy herbicides affect not only broad-leaf plants but permeate entire ecosystems, potentially interfering with the growth processes of all living things, including people.

Those who oppose the use of 2,4,5-T must fight a number of powerful special-interest groups. Ranchers spray the herbicide on their range lands; rice farmers and timber companies use it on their crops; the Forest Service and the Bureau of Land Management (BLM) spray thousands of acres of public forest with 2,4,5-T each year, in preparation for commercial logging operations. Perhaps the most ardent advocates of 2,4,5-T are its manufacturers, especially Dow Chemical.

Much of the controversy centers on another chemical, called TCDD or dioxin, which invariably contaminates 2,4,5-T in the manufacturing process. Dioxin is extremely toxic. The maximum allowable level of dioxin in 2,4,5-

*The Air Force still owns 2.3 million gallons of the poison, estimated to be worth up to $100 million. Most of it is being stored on Johnston Island in the Pacific Ocean; the remainder is in Gulfport, Miss. At first, the Air Force intended to dispose of the stock by burning it at two domestic sites, later amended to a "remote site" outside the United States. For a while there was talk of selling a dilution of it to certain South American countries for agricultural use. The State Department will not allow this until the diluted herbicide is approved for commercial use in the United States. Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) approval has not yet been granted, but it has been urged by *The New York Times* as well as the Air Force.

R. Douglas Clark has recently completed his master's degree in music at Brown University and is at present living in Oregon where he has been actively working with environmental groups.

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